

130 Nathanael (Bartholomew)

The honest skeptic who met Jesus and was promised greater things.

Nathanael came from Cana in Galilee. When his friend Philip told him the Messiah was Jesus of Nazareth, Nathanael scoffed: "Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth?" But he went to see. Jesus greeted him as "an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile" and told him he had seen him under the fig tree. Nathanael's doubt turned at once into one of the earliest confessions in John's Gospel: "thou art the Son of God; thou art the King of Israel." John names him only twice. The first three Gospels never mention a Nathanael, but they list an apostle named Bartholomew beside Philip. For that reason many Christians have long believed the two names belong to one man.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Nathanael</i> , "God has given"
Other name	Probably Bartholomew, "son of Tolmai"; the link is likely but not certain
Home	Cana in Galilee (John 21:2)
Friend	Philip, who brought him to Jesus (John 1:45)
Main passages	John 1:45–51; 21:2
As Bartholomew	Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"Jesus saw Nathanael coming to him, and saith of him, Behold an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile!"

John 1:47, KJV

The life of Nathanael (Bartholomew)

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study. Entries marked "as Bartholomew" depend on the two names being the same man.

- c. AD 27–28

Galilee

● Hears about Jesus

Philip finds Nathanael and says they have found the one Moses and the prophets wrote of, Jesus of Nazareth. Nathanael doubts that anything good can come from Nazareth. *John 1:45–46*
- c. AD 27–28

Galilee

● Meets Jesus

Jesus says he saw Nathanael under the fig tree before Philip called him. Nathanael confesses him as the Son of God and King of Israel. *John 1:47–51*
- c. AD 28

As
Bartholomew

● Chosen as an apostle

After a night of prayer, Jesus names twelve apostles. Bartholomew is listed next to Philip. *Luke 6:12–16*
- c. AD 30

Sea of Tiberias

● Sees the risen Lord

Nathanael of Cana is among seven disciples who go fishing with Peter, catch nothing all night, and meet the risen Jesus on the shore at dawn. *John 21:1–14*
- c. AD 30

As
Bartholomew

● Waits and prays

Bartholomew is with the apostles in the upper room after the ascension, waiting for the promised Spirit. *Acts 1:13–14*

Group notes

Key activities

Nathanael appears only in John, and Bartholomew appears only in the lists of the Twelve. The link rests on three clues: Bartholomew is a family name ("son of Tolmai") that would allow a personal name as well, he is paired with Philip in three lists, and John counts Nathanael among the disciples. Scripture never says directly that they are one person.

-
- 1 Questioned honestly.** He asked, "Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth?" *John 1:46*
 - 2 Came and saw.** Despite his doubt, he went with Philip to meet Jesus. *John 1:46-47*
 - 3 Was known before he came.** Jesus knew his character and had seen him under the fig tree. *John 1:47-48*
 - 4 Confessed Jesus.** He called Jesus "the Son of God" and "the King of Israel." *John 1:49*
 - 5 Received a promise.** Jesus told him he would see heaven open and angels ascending and descending upon the Son of man. *John 1:50-51*
 - 6 Met the risen Christ.** He was one of the seven by the sea when Jesus appeared. *John 21:1-2*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nathanael.

Old Testament

Genesis 28:12	Jacob's ladder; Jesus uses its words to Nathanael (John 1:51)
Echo: Genesis 27:35	Jacob took the blessing "with subtilty"; Nathanael has no guile
Echo: 1 Kings 4:25; Micah 4:4	Sitting under one's fig tree, a picture of peace

New Testament

John 1:45–51	Nathanael meets Jesus
John 21:2	Among the seven who see the risen Jesus by the sea
Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13	Bartholomew listed among the Twelve
Tradition	Eusebius links Bartholomew with India; others say Armenia and martyrdom. Not in Scripture

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Nathanael describe Jesus after their short conversation (John 1:49)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus praised Nathanael's lack of guile even though he had just spoken bluntly about Nazareth. What does this show about honesty?
3. *Apply:* Nathanael brought his doubts to Jesus instead of staying away. What question would you like to bring to Jesus?
4. *Apply:* Jesus knew Nathanael before they met. How does it help you this week to know that God sees you under your "fig tree"?